being collected by the Naxals. The main sources of income were the levy on tendu patta contractors in the summer months and extortion from forest and road contractors. The Naxals were able to raise an estimated Rs 150 crore out of these. The handing of civil works to the Border Roads Organisation, a central government unit, has plugged that source of funding as has the strict watch by intelligence agencies on tendu leaf contractors. In many of the Naxal-affected districts with good internet connectivity, tendu auctions have been held online to stem leakage.

CHARTING THE END GAME

What will it take for the government to formally declare the end of the Naxal movement in Chhattisgarh? "From the security point of view, our objective is to dismantle the leadership and ensure no fresh Maoist cases are reported. In other words, we want to end the Maoist ability to perpetuate violence," says Bastar veteran Sundarraj Pattilingam, IG of the Chhattisgarh Police and in-charge of state police forces in the Bastar region.



"Recent operations have been pinpointed and hugely successful mainly due to the sharing of tech intelligence between the Union govt and state govt agencies"

— AMIT KUMAR, *Additional Director General, Central Zone, CRPF*

The Naxals have an elaborate organisation. At its apex are the politburo, the central committee and the central military commission. Heading the politburo currently is Nambala Keshav Rao, the 70-year-old general secretary who goes by several aliases, Basavaraj and Gaganna among them. The military wing has regional, state and zonal commands with armed militia forming the base of the pyramid (see *The Red Brigade*). Adopting a 'trace, target and neutralise' approach, the Modi government in the past five years has killed 15 top Naxal leaders, including three politburo and 12 central committee members. Police sources say that due to the operational successes of the past year, the number of hardcore fighters in the Naxal ranks in Bastar has come down to 600, from 1,400 three years ago.

Currently, Bastar has three major security vacuum areas, where the writ of the State is not as effective as elsewhere. The Naxals refer to them as 'Liberated Zones'. The most critical is Abujhmaad—literally, the unknown forest—a 4,000 sq. km area, 60 per cent of which lies in Narayanpur district, 15 per cent in Bijapur, 10 per cent in Kanker and 5 per cent in Gadchiroli



SURRENDER POLICY

THE TIP OF THE SPEAR

By **Rahul Noronha** *in Sukma*

IN India's arsenal against Left-wing Extremism, the Naxal surrender policy has emerged as a crucial weapon. By providing Naxal cadres a peaceful exit, the policy has reduced insurgent numbers, disrupted leadership structures and logistical support, and yielded valuable intelligence for counter-insurgency operations. Over the past five years, nearly 3,000 rebels, including mid-level leaders, have surrendered in Chhattisgarh, significantly weakening Naxal influence in its last bastion.

So how does this policy work? The surrender policy offers financial aid, housing, education and employment assistance to Naxals who lay down their arms. An immediate deposit of Rs 25,000 is made into the account of each surrendering cadre, with additional financial rewards based on rank. Militia commanders receive Rs 1 lakh, party